May 12, 2026
Irrigation, Landscaping

This low maintenance method of sub-surface irrigation provides steady and

dependable watering to your plants where they need it most.

Watering a garden can be deceptively wasteful if you're not careful. Factors like evaporation, runoff from overwatering, and varying soil moisture levels can result in plants not receiving the

necessary amount of water they need.

One elegant solution comes from an ancient technique that's been used for thousands of years: Ollas.

This simple, low-tech sub-surface irrigation method is remarkably efficient at hydrating your plants where they need it most — at their roots.

Watering gardens with ollas involves using unglazed clay pots filled with water and covered, then buried in the soil near growing plants. The way it works is the water slowly leaches out of the pots' porous surface and into the surrounding soil near a plant's roots.

When it comes to irrigation, it may not sound like all the rage. But it is a tried-and-true technique.

The reason it's so effective is due to the moisture tension in the soil itself. When the soil is dry, the water in the olla is gradually sucked out of its porous walls. Alternatively, when the soil is wet (like after a rain event), the water stays in the olla until the soil dries out again.

This effective, water-saving approach steadily provides water to the root zone of growing plants, allowing them to use water efficiently when needed, particularly in times of drought.

There are many shapes and size of ollas, but ideally one with a large body and long-tapered neck that easily protrudes above the surface is recommended for easy refilling. You also want to make sure you have a lid to cover the opening to help reduce evaporation and prevent a mosquito frenzy.

It's recommended to refill ollas once a week or until you see the interior water level is about halfway. With drought conditions continuing to have an impact on our area, burying a few clay pots in your garden can be a unique way to sustainably irrigate it.

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Carlos Paris is a conservation field investigator for SAWS. A native of Colombia, Carlos understands the reciprocity between humans and our natural world. With an education background in environmental science and a landscape irrigator license, he's passionate about sustainable water use and protecting our region's most vital resource. Carlos spends his free time hiking and enjoying various parks across the country with his fiancée, Valerie, and dog, Benny.

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